ISSUE 63

NOVEMBER 1, 2026

LAST WEEK IN TÜRKİYE

A weekly roundup of the top news and developments in Türkiye

MARCH 19 PLATFORM
UNITED FOR DEMOCRACY IN TÜRKİYE

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OCTOBER 26, 2026

REMINDERS BY NUMBERS

586 DAYS

since Istanbul Mayor and opposition preseidential candidate Ekrem İmamoğlu was jailed. His trial is still ongoing.

89 DAYS

since elected Üsküdar Mayor Sinem Dedetaş was jailed pending trial, despite not being convicted of any crime.

31 DAYS

since retired police officer Ali Şekeroğlu committed suicide during a protest over pensioners' financial struggles in front of the Constitutional Court

494 DAYS

since attorney Mehmet Pehlivan was arrested. He remains imprisoned despite the reported expiration of the maximum legal period for pretrial detention.

SÖZCÜ EDITOR-IN-CHIEF ERCÜMENT İŞLEYEN DETAINED

Ercüment İşleyen, editor-in-chief of Sözcü.com.tr, was detained in Istanbul on October 27, 2026, in yet another troubling development for press freedom in Türkiye. İşleyen was taken to the Vatan Police Department, while authorities had not publicly disclosed the reason for his detention at the time of the initial reports. The detention raises renewed concerns about the pressures facing journalists and independent media in a country where press freedom continues to be under threat. Targeting journalists and media figures undermines the public's right to information and raises serious questions about the ability of the press to hold those in power accountable.

FOUR WORKERS DIE IN TORNADO AT ANTALYA CONSTRUCTION SITE

Four workers died and one was injured when a tornado struck a construction site in Antalya's Kepez district on October 27, destroying two containers where workers were staying and toppling a tower crane. Three of the workers who died were Syrian nationals. The tragedy raises serious concerns about the safety and living conditions of construction workers, who are often left vulnerable to dangerous conditions. Protecting workers requires more than condolences after lives are lost—it requires safe working and living environments, proper emergency preparedness, and accountability for preventable risks.

45 PEOPLE, MOSTLY TRANS WOMEN, DETAINED IN RAIDS ACROSS TÜRKIYE

Turkish police detained 45 people, most of them trans women, during coordinated raids across seven cities on October 24. Authorities are primarily pursuing “obscenity” allegations based on social media posts, with prosecutors also citing claims about “encouraging gender-neutralization.” LGBTQ+ rights advocates have condemned the operation as another attempt to criminalize trans existence and suppress LGBTQ+ visibility. The raids follow a wider crackdown in September that resulted in dozens of arrests and restrictions on LGBTQ+ organizations and activists online.

FOUR MORE ISTANBUL MUNICIPALITIES JOIN OPPOSITION YENI PARTI

The mayors of Bakırköy, Küçükçekmece, Çatalca, and Büyükçekmece, along with 86 municipal council members, announced their move to Yeni Parti, continuing a major realignment in Istanbul politics. The decision comes amid mounting tensions surrounding opposition-run municipalities and a new police operation targeting Bakırköy Municipality. During the announcement, Bakırköy Mayor Ayşegül Ovalıoğlu criticized the authorities' actions, describing dawn raids and detentions as unacceptable and calling for intervention. Opposition representatives accused the government of escalating pressure against political opponents as concerns grow over democracy, the rule of law, and the will of voters.

SIX STUDENTS DETAINED AFTER PROTESTS AGAINST EDUCATION MINISTER

Two university students, Nehir Tekin and Nevin Dizdar, were jailed after hanging a banner protesting Education Minister Yusuf Tekin ahead of his visit to Kadıköy High School in Istanbul. Then, four more students have been detained and subsequently released in dawn raids on their homes for participating in protests demanding their release. The arrests have sparked outrage among student groups, who say peaceful protest is a fundamental right and are calling for the release of those detained. The crackdown has raised serious concerns about freedom of expression and the growing criminalization of dissent in Türkiye.

JOURNALIST İSMAIL ARI FACES UP TO FIVE YEARS AND FOUR MONTHS IN PRISON

BirGün reporter İsmail Arı, arrested on October 21, faces up to five years and four months in prison following a complaint by former RTÜK chairman and current Türk Telekom CEO Ebubekir Şahin. Charged with spreading misleading information and insult over two social media posts, Arı will appear in court on November 19. Arı denied all allegations: “I was simply doing my job as a journalist. I neither insulted anyone nor spread misleading information.”

ANOTHER OPPOSITION MUNICIPALITY UNDER ATTACK

In an investigation targeting Istanbul's Bakırköy Municipality, prosecutors requested the detention of 40 out of 63 people taken into custody and judicial supervision for 17 others. Six individuals were released following questioning. Prosecutors also sought house arrest for the 86-year-old father of Mayor Ayşegül Ovalıoğlu and a travel ban for her uncle. The case adds to ongoing legal proceedings involving municipal officials in Türkiye.

SINEM DEDETAŞ RELEASED FROM PRISON, PLACED UNDER HOUSE ARREST

Sinem Dedetaş, the elected mayor of Istanbul's Üsküdar district who was suspended from office following her arrest, has been released from prison under house arrest. Her lawyer, Akın Atalay, confirmed her release and expressed hope that other detainees would also regain their freedom. On Republic Day, October 29, Dedetaş had marked her 90th day in detention, describing the painful experience of celebrating the Republic alone in a prison cell.

TÜRKIYE CELEBRATES 103 YEARS OF THE REPUBLIC

Türkiye marked the Republic’s 103rd anniversary on October 29, 2026. Founded under Mustafa Kemal Atatürk’s leadership following the War of Independence, the Republic established national sovereignty as its guiding principle. Parliament proclaimed the Republic on October 29, 1923, electing Atatürk as its first president. Today, 103 years later, the anniversary invites reflection on how the Republic’s founding ideals of popular sovereignty, democracy, equality, and the rule of law are upheld in contemporary Türkiye.

POVERTY THRESHOLD RISES TO 4.4 TIMES THE MINIMUM WAGE

According to Türk-İş, Türkiye’s monthly poverty threshold for a family of four reached 123,856 lira in October 2026, while the hunger threshold rose to 38,024 lira. These figures represent approximately 4.4 and 1.4 times the minimum wage of 28,075 lira, respectively. The monthly living cost for a single worker reached 49,124 lira, while annual food inflation in Ankara stood at 33.83%.

OSMAN KAVALA MARKS 3,287 DAYS BEHIND BARS

As of October 31, 2026, civil society activist and human rights defender Osman Kavala has spent 3,287 days in detention. First detained on October 18, 2017, Kavala was acquitted in the Gezi Park trial in February 2020 but immediately detained again on separate charges. Despite a 2019 European Court of Human Rights ruling ordering his release and repeated calls from the Council of Europe, Kavala remains imprisoned.

OVER 7,200 WORKERS LAID OFF SINCE JANUARY AMID ALLEGATIONS OF ANTI-UNION PRACTICES

At least 7,241 workers have lost their jobs across 15 workplaces in Türkiye between January and October 2026, including 380 dismissed following union organizing efforts. Labor protests continue at nine workplaces. At Domino Textile in Bolu, 60 workers were dismissed on October 22, including 25 union members, amid allegations of anti-union pressure. At Planet Trakya, a worker was reportedly dismissed without severance pay after demanding unpaid overtime.

NEW CONNECTIONS EMERGE IN TÜRKIYE'S FUND SCANDAL INVESTIGATION

New revelations have linked Tera Investment Holding, a company at the center of Türkiye's ongoing fund investigation, to former senior government officials. Necip Fazıl Kaymak, the holding's chief adviser to the board, is the son of former Samsun Governor Osman Kaymak. He previously served for approximately six and a half years in the Presidential Finance Office, holding senior positions, and later worked as an adviser at the Ministry of National Defense before joining Tera Holding in May 2026.

OPPOSITION MAYOR ARRESTED ALONGSIDE 33 OTHERS IN ADANA INVESTIGATION

Çukurova Mayor Emrah Kozay was arrested and suspended from office following a corruption investigation into municipal contracts and procurement practices in Adana. Among the 34 people arrested were former Mayor Soner Çetin and two deputy mayors. Of the 49 people initially detained on October 19, 15 were released under judicial supervision. Prosecutors allege bribery, aggravated fraud, bid-rigging, and organized criminal activity. Kozay, who left the Republican People’s Party (CHP) in August 2026, subsequently joined Yeni Parti, an opposition party formed amid growing political tensions in Türkiye. His arrest comes amid a wider wave of investigations and detentions targeting opposition politicians and elected municipal officials.

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COP31: CIVIL SOCIETY CALLS FOR FEMINIST, GREEN, AND PUBLIC-LED CLIMATE TRANSFORMATION

Women’s organizations, LGBTQ+ groups, environmental activists, trade unions, and human rights defenders issued a joint appeal ahead of COP31, demanding climate justice rooted in gender equality and social protection. Their 13 demands include a just transition away from fossil fuels, workers’ rights, public care services, gender-responsive climate financing, and protection for vulnerable communities. The coalition urged COP31 to ensure women and LGBTQ+ people have meaningful decision-making power in climate policies.

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THREE PEOPLE DIE IN CAPPADOCIA ROCK FORMATION COLLAPSE

Three people lost their lives and five others were injured after a rock formation collapsed in Türkiye's Cappadocia region on October 29, following heavy rainfall. The tragedy has raised concerns about visitor safety and the monitoring of geological hazards in one of the country's most popular tourist destinations. The incident highlights the importance of preventive safety measures, regular geological assessments, and effective warning systems to protect visitors and local communities from potentially life-threatening risks.

DOG STRANGLED DURING MUNICIPAL COLLECTION OPERATION

Disturbing footage from Akşehir, Konya, on October 31 shows a dog being restrained with a catch pole around its neck during a municipal collection operation. Witnesses can be heard shouting that the animal is being strangled, while subsequent footage shows the dog lying motionless. The incident has sparked outrage and renewed concerns about the methods used to collect stray animals and the lack of accountability for animal welfare violations. Just days after officials announced that the nationwide collection campaign was complete, this incident raises an urgent question: who is protecting the animals being taken off the streets?

WORLD MEDICAL ASSOCIATION CALLS FOR RESTORATION OF TURKISH MEDICAL ASSOCIATION'S OVERSIGHT POWERS

The World Medical Association urged Türkiye to restore the Turkish Medical Association's authority over professional ethics and disciplinary oversight. Following a Constitutional Court ruling that took effect in January 2026, approximately 1,700 disciplinary cases remain unresolved. In its October 28 statement, the association also raised concerns over the detention of forensic physicians involved in a 2009 autopsy, calling for judicial fairness and protection of medical professionals' independence.